I ensured that such people got their due share of rewards, mostly timely promotion. ISRO scientists and engineers—at least the ones with no adverse remarks on their annual confidential reports—were eligible for a promotion every three years. But in many cases the promotion was delayed or denied due to bureaucratic bungling or petty score settling. I ensured that the deserving candidates in my team got promotion without delay. This was reason enough for those who I threw out of the team to murmur that if anyone in ISRO wanted a promotion, he or she should work in Nambi's team. I laughed at the stupidity of such remarks.

I had by now earned multiple epithets—a 'bulldozer' for lethargic collaborators and co-workers; a 'blue-eyed boy' of the ISRO chairman for my jealous colleagues; and a passionate yet pushy boss for the others. On being called as any of these behind my back, I neither regaled nor riled.

As we assimilated the components and started mock assembly, the ISRO board decided to put in place the mandatory non-conformance committee and the waiver committee. The non-conformance committee was essentially a quality control mechanism. It would study every component for its structural and behavioural aberration. In a rocket, every component and function has a margin within which they can vary. The conformance committee would look into the degree of variation and decide if it conforms to the standards and set margins. But being on the border or even outside the margin, in some cases, may not be a sole reason for rejection. In other words, if a variation is not significant enough to adversely affect the overall performance of the component, sub-system or the system, the waiver committee would waive off the variation and accept it.

Here I made a demand, which many found unreasonable, even impossible. I would head both the non-conformance committee and the waiver committee. Not that I did not anticipate opposition to this seemingly outrageous demand. Traditionally, and rightly so, the two committees are headed by different people. After all, what's the point in the same person presiding over a fault-finding panel and overruling the fault by virtue of heading a panel of appeal?